

Notes

Unit 5

5

Listening and Reading Skills

Syllabus

Meaning, importance and purpose of listening, Listening Vs. Hearing, Types of listening, Barriers to effective listening, Traits of a good listener, Introduction, Meaning and Purpose of reading, Tips for improving reading skills, Techniques for effective reading : Skimming, Scanning, Structure of, text, Punctuation, Author's & Reader's point of view, Reading Comprehension.

Contents

- 5.1 Listening
- 5.2 Introduction, Meaning and Purpose of Reading
- 5.3 Tips for Improving Reading Skills
- 5.4 Techniques for Effective Reading
- 5.5 Reading Comprehension

Learning objectives :

- Define listening and explain its significance in effective communication.
- Highlight the purpose of listening in personal and professional contexts.
- Explore the role of listening in building relationships and understanding others' perspectives.
- Differentiate between listening and hearing with examples.
- Illustrate why active listening is more effective than passive hearing.
- Identify and define different types of listening.
- Practice applying various listening types to improve communication outcomes.
- Identify common barriers to effective listening, including physical, psychological and environmental factors.
- Develop strategies to overcome the barriers for better understanding.
- Discuss the purpose of reading in gaining knowledge, improving comprehension and fostering critical thinking.
- Identify practical tips for enhancing reading speed, accuracy, and comprehension.
- Define and practice techniques such as skimming and scanning for various reading purposes.
- Explore the differences between the author's point of view and the reader's interpretation.
- Practice strategies for improving comprehension, including identifying main ideas, inferring meaning and analyzing content.

5.1 Listening

- Communication cannot be complete without the receiver (listener). In organizations, as professionals, we would be at the receiving end of communication more than at the sending end. As the receivers of communication, we would be required to listen to instructions from our managers, requirements of our clients, various information from all kinds of stakeholders of business and sharing from our colleagues.
- We take action, do our work or take a decision from what we have listened from all of the above. Hence, we can say that most of our activities depend on listening. If we do not listen effectively, we may end up doing mistakes. Even in our personal lives people become friends of those who are good listeners.
- This makes listening a very important activity.

5.1.1 Meaning, Importance and Purpose of Listening

- Listening is the process of receiving, constructing meaning from it and responding to spoken or non-verbal messages. Listening is a key skill in effective communication, fostering understanding, building relationships and facilitating problem-solving.

5.1.2 Listening Vs. Hearing

- When the sound waves strikes the ear drums, vibrations are transferred through our nerves and our brain secretes some chemicals, which helps us to register the sound, which is hearing, which is an involuntary act. For example, when someone plays music in the background while you're working, you may hear the sound but not focus on its lyrics or melody.
- But, when we hear some sound, recognize it, understand, interpret, analyse and respond, then it is called listening. Hence we can say that hearing is merely a physical act, while listening is a more involved activity which is at physical as well as mental level. Listening requires concentration and engagement, making it a physical and mental activity. For instance, in a classroom, hearing a lecture might mean passively perceiving the teacher's voice. In contrast, listening entails taking notes, asking questions and reflecting on the content.



- The difference between listening and hearing are :

Hearing	Listening
A sound / noise comes into your ear without you making an effort.	You pay attention and try to listen to a sound.
You do not make conscious decision to pay attention to the sound.	You deliberately pay attention to the sound.
It is a passive process.	It is an active process.

Hearing is a physiological activity.	Listening requires intellectual and emotional involvement.
Hearing doesn't lead to any learning.	Listening leads to learning.
Hearing may not result into any action or response.	Listening results into a response either as a reply or an action.
Hearing means perceiving the sound.	Listening means understanding information with involvement of body and mind.

➤ Why listening is more important than hearing

In the modern world, where distractions and rapid communication dominate, the attention span of people have drastically reduced. The ability to listen has become more critical than ever. Listening helps in many ways in personal as well as professional life :

1. Improved communication in relationships

- **Example :** In personal relationships, hearing your partner's words without truly understanding their emotions can lead to miscommunication. Actively listening to their concerns-interpreting their tone, observing body language and offering thoughtful responses-builds trust and emotional connection.
- **Importance :** Listening fosters empathy and strengthens relationships, reducing conflicts in both personal and professional settings.

2. Effective decision-making

- **Example :** In the workplace, a manager who merely hears employees' ideas may miss critical insights. By actively listening, they can evaluate suggestions, address concerns and make informed decisions.
- **Importance :** Listening ensures that diverse perspectives are acknowledged, leading to better collaboration and innovation.

3. Handling overwhelming information

- **Example :** In the digital age, we are constantly bombarded with notifications, media and conversations. Hearing alone doesn't help us process this overload. Listening allows us to filter relevant information, focus on priorities and act effectively.
- **Importance :** In a world of information overload, listening is key to clarity and focus.

4. Resolving conflicts

- **Example :** During a negotiation or argument, hearing the other person's words without listening to their intent can escalate the conflict. By actively listening, you can identify the root cause, find common ground and resolve disagreements.
- **Importance :** Active listening is an essential skill for conflict resolution, promoting mutual understanding and solutions.

5. Enhancing learning

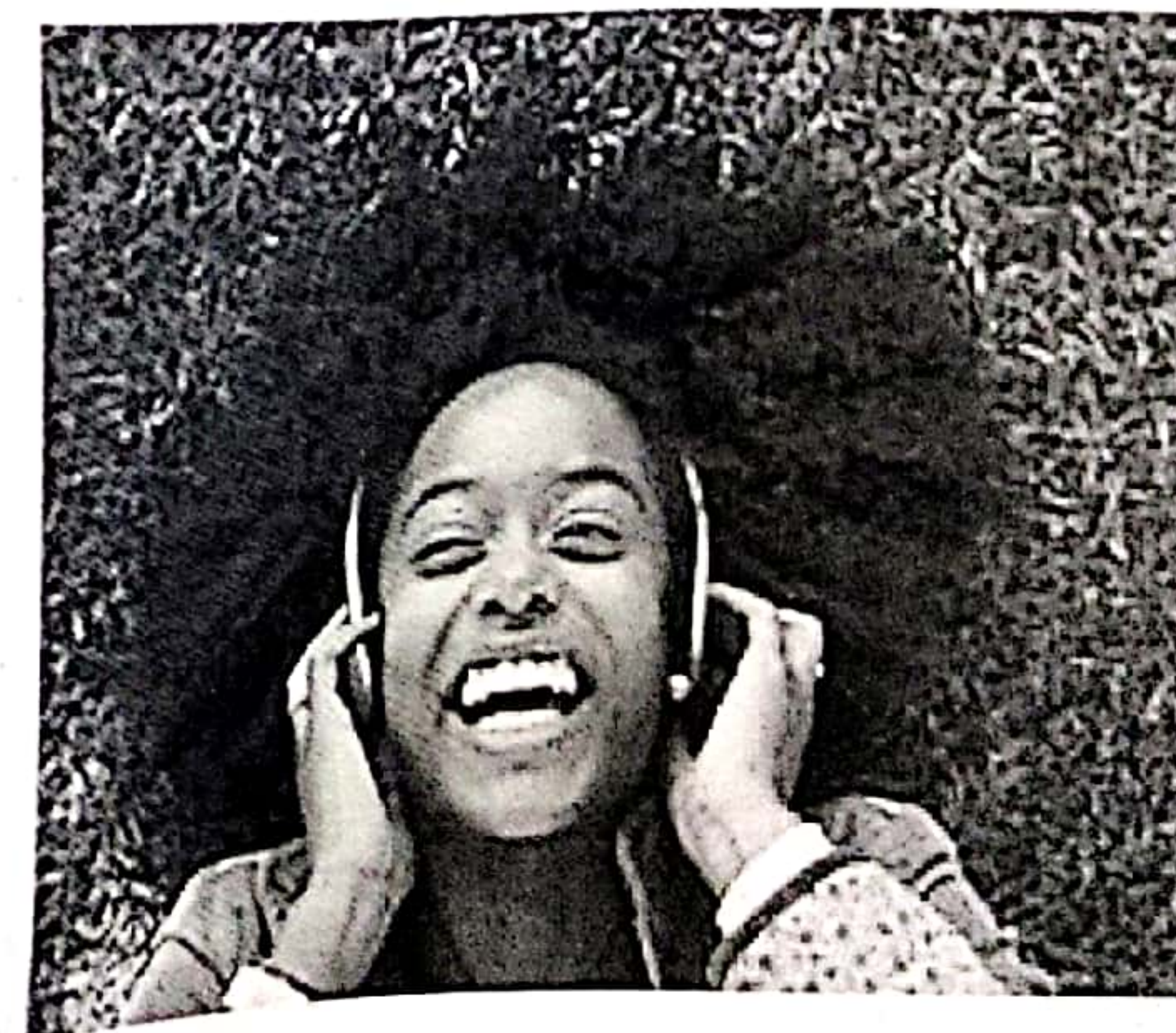
- **Example :** In educational settings, students who merely hear the teacher may struggle to retain information. Listening, which involves engaging with the material, asking questions and making connections, leads to deeper understanding.
- **Importance :** Listening is vital for absorbing knowledge and fostering critical thinking.

5.1.3 Types of Listening

Listening is an essential communication skill that varies depending on the purpose. Listening is classified, based on how involved our brains are, when we listen to a certain type of communication." Following are different types of listening with examples :

1. Appreciative listening :

- When we listen to enjoy or get pleasure, it is called appreciative listening.



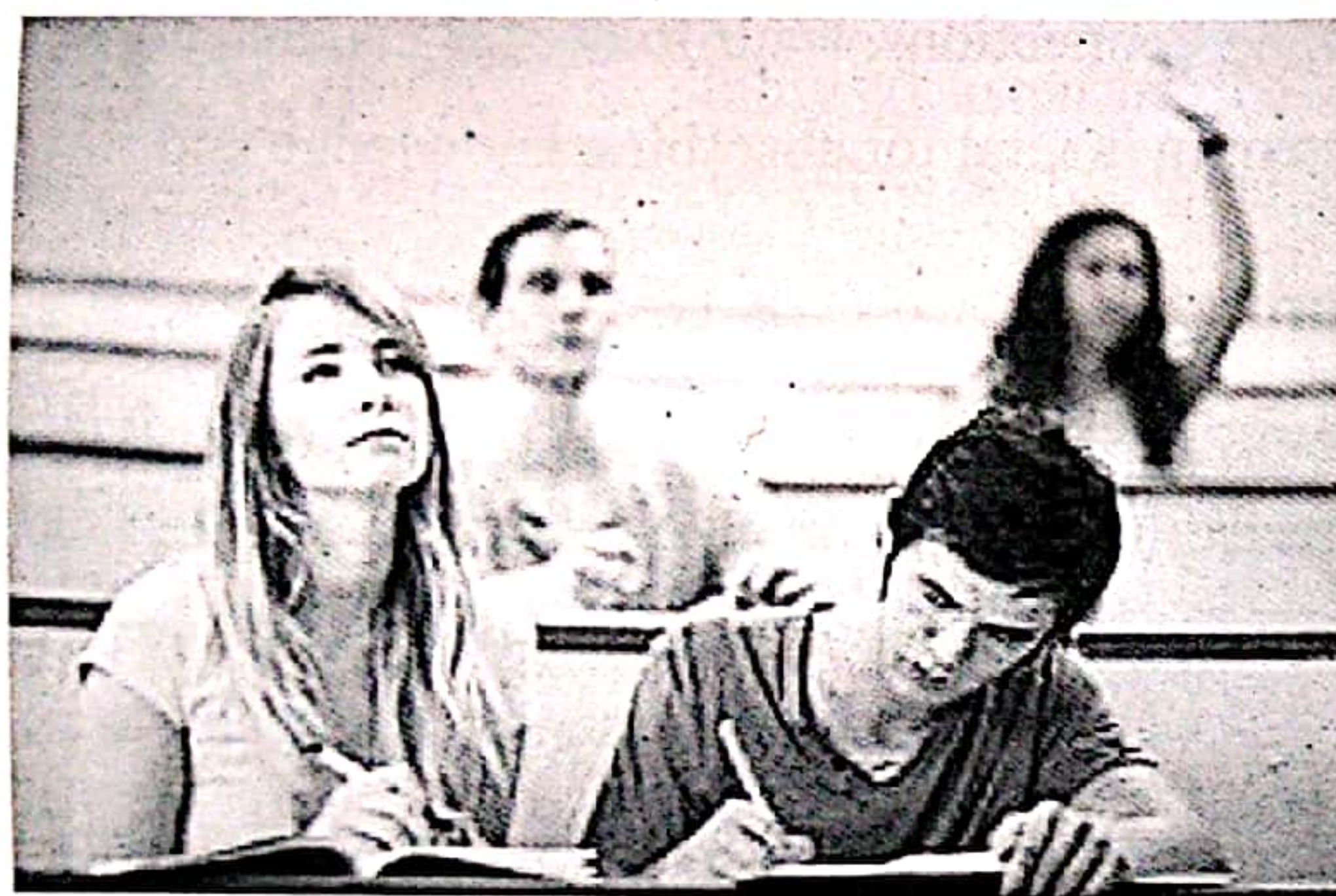
Appreciative listening

- **Examples :**
 - Listening to your favorite music or podcast after a long day to relax and unwind.
 - Attending a live concert or a stand-up comedy show, focusing on the rhythm, tone or humor.

- Watching a movie or a storytelling event and savoring the narrative and delivery style.
- **Importance :**
 - Helps reduce stress and improves emotional well-being.
 - Encourages creativity and inspiration by exposing listeners to new ideas and forms of expression.

2. Comprehensive listening :

- When we listen to understand or learn, it is called comprehensive listening. It requires focus, attention and cognitive engagement.



Comprehensive listening

- **Examples :**
 - Listening to a lecture in school to grasp a new concept, like the theory of gravity or world history.
 - Taking instructions from a GPS or a guide to reach a destination.
 - Attending a training session at work to understand the company's new software.
- **Importance :**
 - Critical for academic and professional success.
 - Enables better retention of information and fosters a deeper understanding of topics.
- **Tips for comprehensive listening :**
 - Take notes to capture key points.
 - Ask clarifying questions when needed to ensure understanding.

3. Empathetic listening :

- When we listen to a distressed friend to understand his / her feelings or when we put ourselves in other person's place to understand their situation, it is called empathetic listening. There is a focus on understanding the emotions and perspectives of others, fostering a connection by putting oneself in their shoes. It often involves not only hearing the words but also observing non-verbal cues such as tone of voice, facial expressions, and body language.



Empathetic listening

- **Examples :**
 - Listening to a distressed friend who has recently faced a breakup, offering support without judgment.
 - A therapist attentively listening to a patient to understand their feelings and underlying issues.
 - Parents listening to their child's concerns about school or friends, acknowledging their feelings.
- **Importance :**
 - Builds trust and deepens relationships.
 - Helps others feel valued, understood and less alone.
 - Plays a vital role in conflict resolution and emotional support.
 - Helps HR professionals to resolve conflicts and provide emotional support to employees thereby fostering a positive environment.

4. Critical listening :

- Whenever we listen to judge, evaluate or make a decision, then it is called critical listening. It requires discerning the credibility, logic and relevance of the message.



Critical listening

- **Examples :**

- A judge in court listening to arguments from both sides to deliver a fair verdict.
- A consumer listening to a salesperson's pitch to determine if the product meets their needs.
- A hiring manager interviewing candidates to evaluate their qualifications and suitability for a role.

- **Importance :**

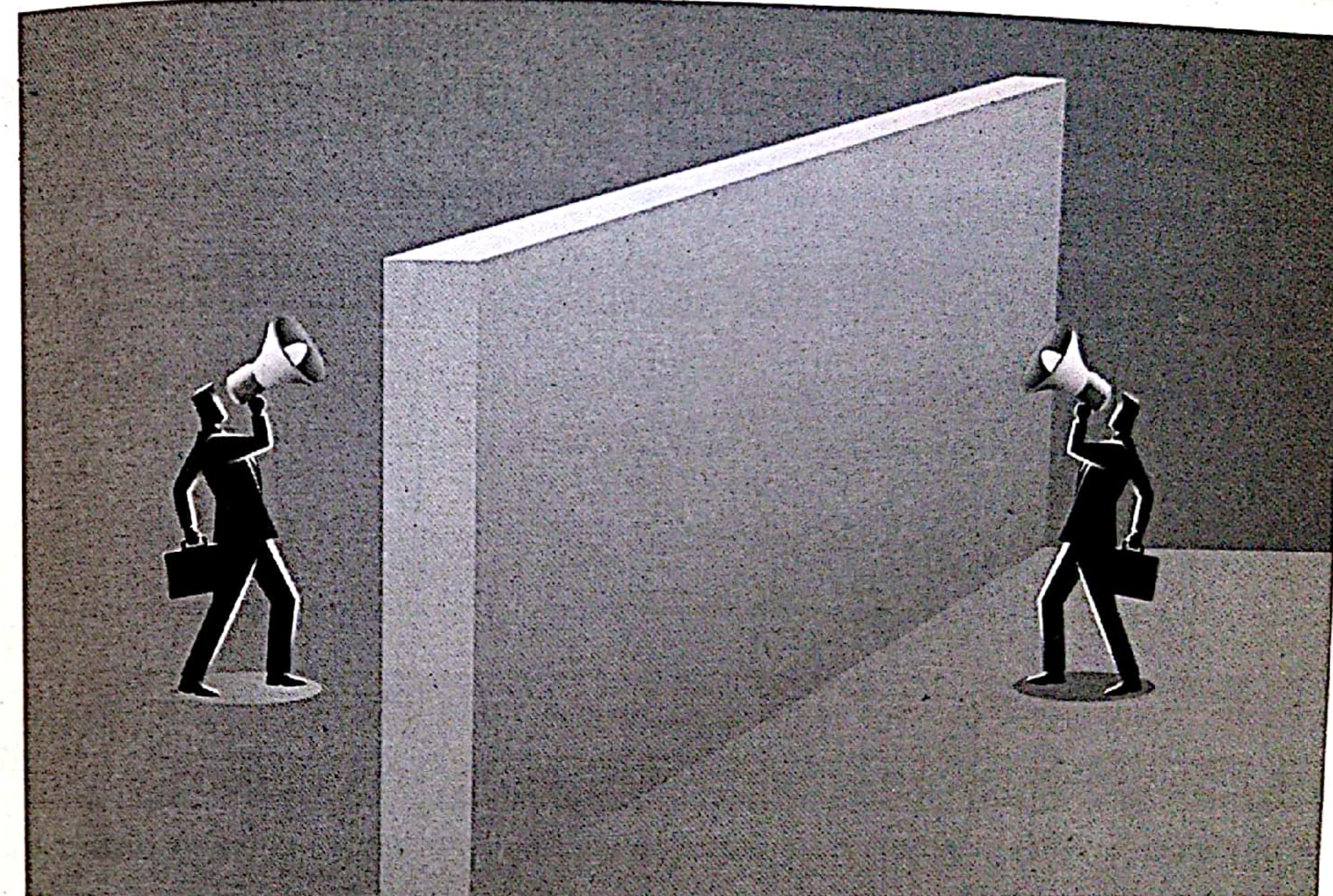
- Helps in making informed and rational decisions.
- Enables the identification of biases, inconsistencies or persuasive techniques.

- **How to enhance critical listening :**

- Pay attention to evidence and reasoning.
- Be aware of emotional appeals or manipulative tactics.

Each type of listening serves a distinct purpose and requires varying levels of cognitive and emotional engagement. Appreciative listening nurtures joy and creativity; comprehensive listening facilitates learning and understanding; empathetic listening builds trust and emotional bonds; and critical listening ensures well-informed decisions.

5.1.4 Barriers to Effective Listening



Barriers to effective listening

Effective listening is a crucial skill for communication, but several barriers can impede the process. These barriers can be categorized into physical, psychological, cultural and environmental factors. Identifying and addressing these challenges is essential for improving listening skills.

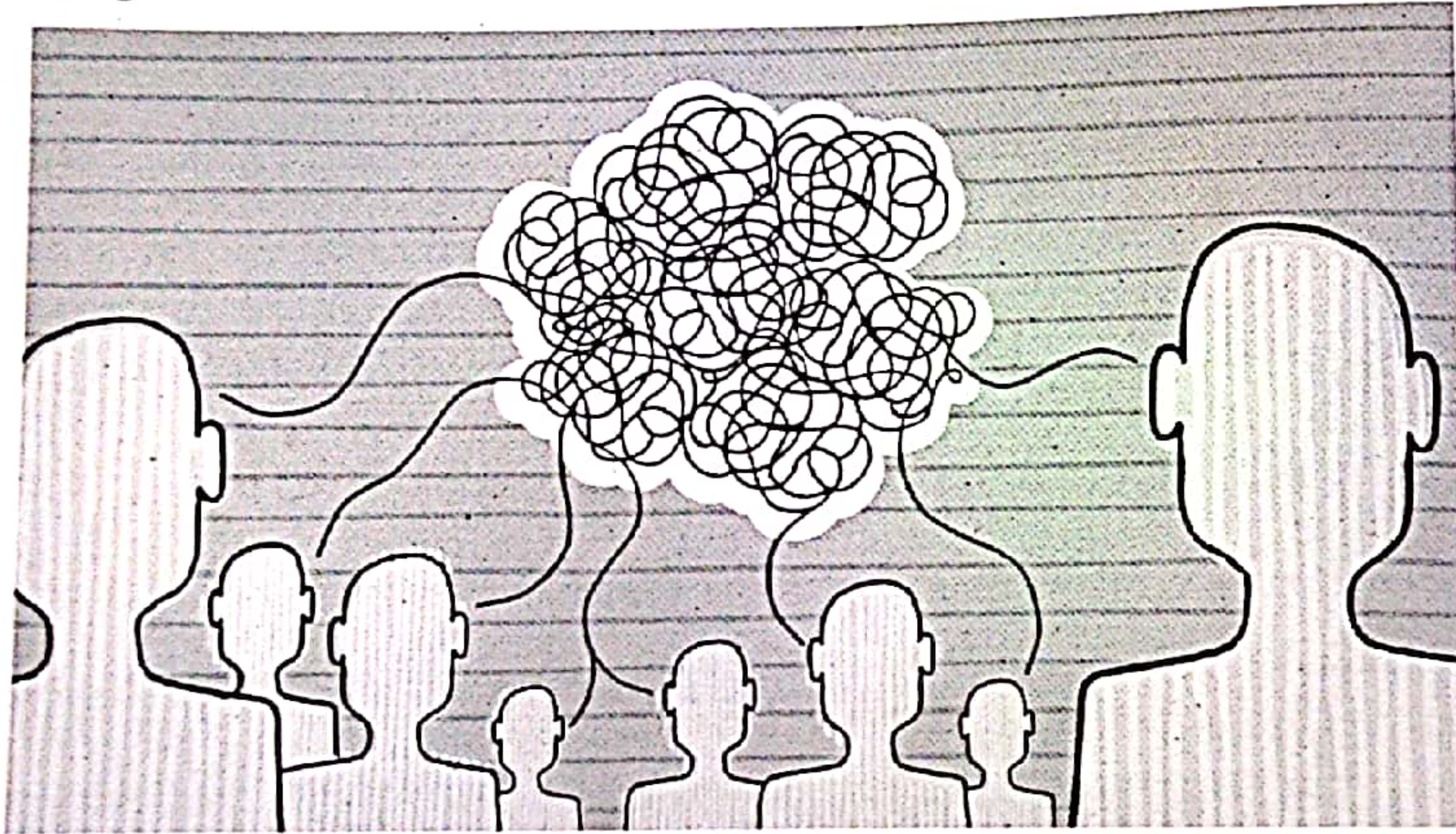
1. Physical barriers

These refer to obstacles related to the environment or the listener's physical state. Physical noise, hearing impairment and fatigue are the physical barriers.

- **Noise :** Loud sounds from traffic, machinery or other distractions can hinder concentration.
- **Hearing impairment :** Physical disabilities affecting the auditory system can make listening difficult.
- **Fatigue :** When a listener is tired, they may struggle to focus on the message.
- The impact of these physical barriers is that they make it hard to hear or process the message clearly. In order to overcome these barriers, one must find a quiet place and fresh mind whenever any crucial discussion has to be done.

2. Psychological barriers

Internal factors that arise from the listener's mental or emotional state. These internal factors include a prejudice or bias towards either the listener or the topic, stress, ego and selective listening.



- **Prejudice or Bias** : Preconceived notions about the speaker or topic can distort the listener's interpretation.
- **Stress or Anxiety** : A listener who is preoccupied with personal issues may find it hard to focus.
- **Ego** : Believing one's own opinions are superior may lead to dismissing others' points of view.
- **Selective listening** : Focusing only on what aligns with personal beliefs and ignoring other points.

These barriers prevent open-mindedness and hinder the ability to fully comprehend the message.

3. Cultural barriers

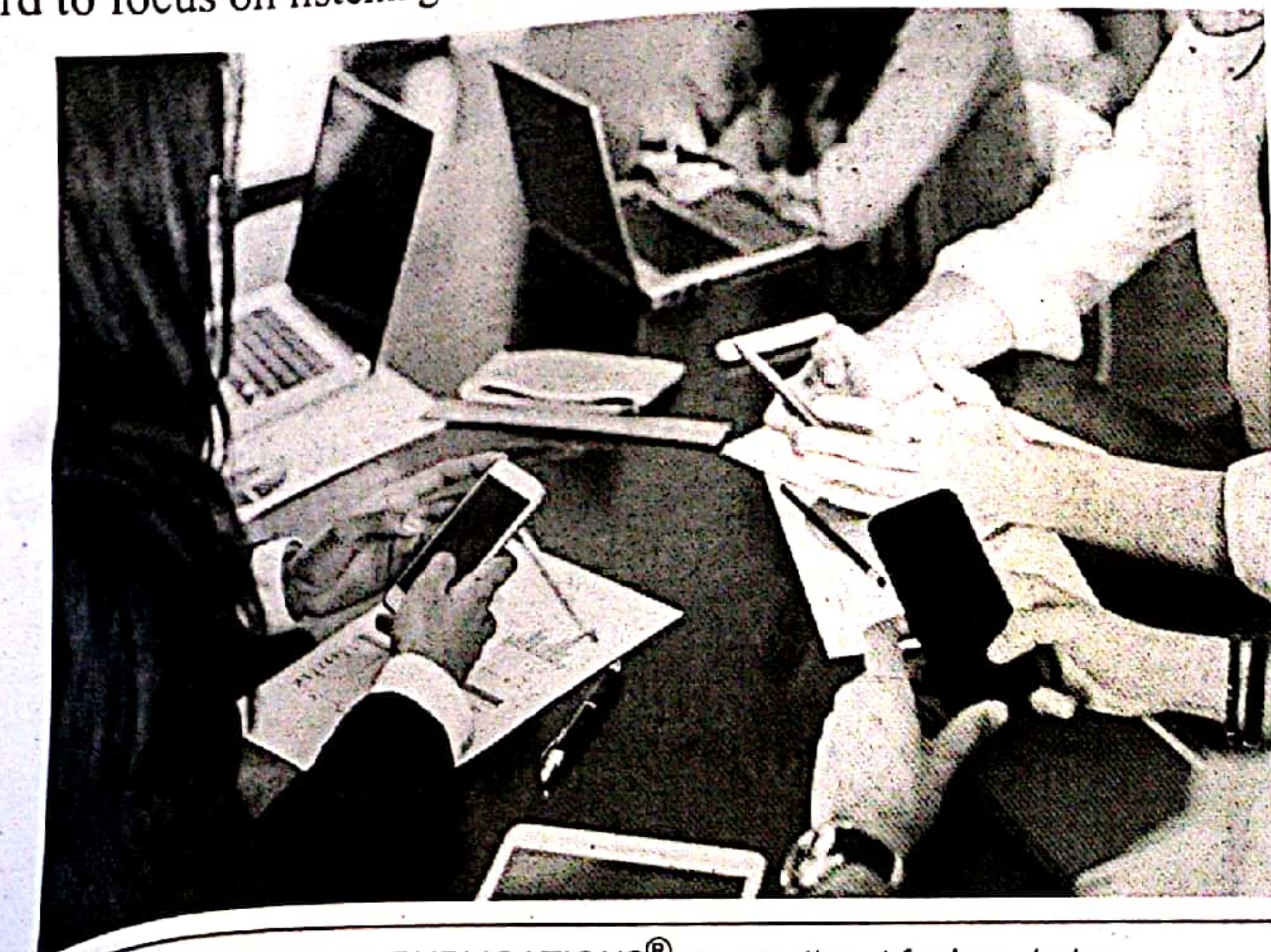
Differences in language, customs or communication styles can interfere with effective listening. Language differences and assumptions due to different culture results into misunderstandings and confusion.



- **Language differences** : A speaker using unfamiliar vocabulary or accents can be difficult to understand.
 - **Cultural norms** : Variations in non-verbal cues, such as gestures or eye contact, can lead to misinterpretation.
 - **Assumptions** : Stereotypes or lack of cultural awareness can create misunderstandings.
- Cultural barriers may cause miscommunication and reduce mutual understanding.

4. Environmental barriers

Environmental barriers are external distractions that make it difficult for the listener to focus on the speaker. Physical environment, multitasking and technological interference makes it hard to focus on listening.



- **Poor room conditions** : Inadequate lighting, uncomfortable seating or a poorly ventilated room can distract listeners.
- **Multitasking** : Trying to listen while engaged in other activities reduces attention. For example, listening to a colleague while making a power point presentation.
- **Technological interference** : Notifications or interruptions from devices can divert focus. This is seen in both personal and professional lives. At home during dinner time when family members are talking but your focus is on the notifications from Instagram or facebook, while at office mostly during any meeting or seminar, people tend to check their mobile phones frequently dividing their attention.

5. Speaker-related barriers

Issues stemming from the way the speaker conveys their message are called speaker related barriers. Here the communication skill of the speaker may be lacking which leaves the listener either uninterested or confused. They make it difficult for the listener to stay engaged or understand the message.

- **Monotone delivery** : A lack of vocal variety may bore the listener.
- **Unclear communication** : Complex jargon or vague ideas can confuse the audience.
- **Overloading information** : Sharing too much at once can overwhelm the listener.

5.1.5 Traits of a Good Listener

Following are the traits of a good listener :

1. **Being non-evaluative** : When we evaluate or judge a person, we don't listen to them carefully or may disagree with their viewpoint. To listen with concentration, one must pay attention to the speech and not the speaker. Sometimes we try judging people based on their outer appearance and it may act as a distraction. So to become a good listener, we must pay more attention to the communication and stop being evaluative.
2. **Paraphrasing** : Confirming with the speaker whether you have listened to them correctly or not by repeating what they said, is called paraphrasing. When we paraphrase from time to time, the speaker understands that we are listening carefully. If we have not received the information correctly, then the speaker gets the chance to correct us, which results in making the communication more effective.

While paraphrasing, one must use sentences like.....

"Are you trying to say that.....?"

"Does it mean that.....?"

3. **Reflecting hidden feelings** : When a friend shares with us his / her situation, he / she may not share the underlying feelings that they are going through. If we reflect those unshared feelings, then they are encouraged to share more.

Eg. "I understand the kind of tension you are going through."

4. **Reflecting implications** : After listening, if we think beyond the topic and reflect upon the practical applications or whatever the communication implies, then it shows that we are listening with concentration. This encourages the speaker to share more information.

Eg. "Do you mean that if we do this.....then the result would be.....?"

5. **Inviting further contributions** : As a good listener we must sometimes ask the speaker directly to share more information. This enhances the communication.

Eg. "Please clarify more on this"

"Could you please throw more light on this ?"

"Kindly explain with examples."

6. **Responding non-verbally** : The body language of the listener communicates to the speaker whether he / she is listening with concentration or not or not listening at all. Some of the signs that indicates this are :

- Sitting straight shows that you are listening with interest.
- Leaning backwards shows disinterest and lethargy.
- Leaning forward shows that you are very much interested in listening and too much involved.
- Nodding your head to show you are listening.
- Making an eye contact to show you are listening.
- Facial expressions shows whether we are listening or not.

If we imbibe all the above qualities, we can improve our listening.

Quick bites :

- ✓ Listening and hearing are different in which hearing is just a physical activity while listening requires more involvement.
- ✓ There are four types of listening based on the purpose of listening : Appreciative listening for pleasure, empathetic listening for understanding other's emotions, comprehensive listening for understanding and critical listening for analyzing.
- ✓ There are physical barriers, psychological barriers, environmental barriers, cultural barriers and speaker related barriers due to which listening can become ineffective.

- ✓ A good listener must be non-evaluative, respond non-verbally, reflect hidden feeling, reflect implications and paraphrase from time to time to make listening effective.

5.2 Introduction, Meaning and Purpose of Reading

Reading is a fundamental skill that involves decoding written or printed language to derive meaning. It is not just a mechanical process but an intellectual and emotional activity that enables comprehension, critical thinking and creativity. In organizations, a professional spends a considerable amount of time in reading e-mails, instructions, reports, proposals, circulars, newsletters etc. and they have to either respond, make decision or act based on their understanding of these reading material.

Meaning and purpose of reading

Reading is the process of recognizing symbols (letters and words), interpreting them and understanding their meaning in context.

The purpose of reading varies depending on the context :

- **Gaining knowledge** : Reading textbooks, research papers or articles to learn new concepts.
- **Entertainment** : Enjoying novels, poetry or comics for leisure.
- **Communication** : Understanding written instructions, emails or text messages.
- **Skill development** : Reading self-help books, manuals or guides to improve personal or professional abilities.

Importance of reading :

1. Reading helps in knowledge acquisition. It expands our understanding of the world and keeps us informed about various subjects. For example, reading a book on history provides insights into past civilizations and their impact on the present, reading a blog gives information about a particular topic.
2. Regular reading enhances vocabulary, grammar and overall communication ability. For example reading novels or newspapers or any articles on the internet introduces readers to diverse words and sentence structures.
3. Reading fosters the ability to evaluate arguments, identify biases and draw conclusions. It enhances critical thinking and analysis of the reader. For example, reading an editorial helps analyze opinions and form one's own perspective.

4. Reading provides mental stimulation. Engaging with books and articles keeps the brain active and reduces the risk of cognitive decline. For example, reading about different topics provides a food for thought to the reader to further think and analyse the topic.
5. Reading helps in stress reduction. Immersing oneself in a good story or calming text can alleviate stress and promote relaxation.

Types of reading

1. **Extensive reading** : Reading large amounts of material for general understanding and enjoyment is called extensive reading. It helps in improving reading fluency, vocabulary acquisition and overall comprehension. Extensive reading involves focussing on meaning rather than details. It involves reading a variety of texts and encourages a love for reading and increases exposure to language.

Example : Reading a novel or a magazine.

2. **Intensive reading** : Reading carefully with a focus on understanding details, structure and vocabulary is called intensive reading. It is used to develop deeper comprehension, critical thinking and language skills. It involves focusing on analyzing grammar, vocabulary and sentence structure. It includes reading shorter more complex texts. Summarizing, answering questions and translating needs intensive reading.

Example : Reading a research paper or study material.

3. **Skimming** : Quickly going through text to get the main idea or general overview of a text is called skimming. It is used to grasp the overall concept without going into the details.

Example : Skimming a blog post to decide if it's worth reading fully.

Skimming can be used for :

1. For reading newspaper and magazines for headlines.
2. While previewing a book or article before reading in detail.
3. For finding the main argument in an essay.

How to skim :

1. Read titles, headings and subheadings.
 2. Look at bold or italicized words.
 3. Read the first and last sentences of paragraphs.
 4. Glance through bullet points and summarise.
4. **Scanning** : Searching for specific information within a text is called scanning. It is used to find particular information like names, dates, keywords, figures etc.
- Example** : Scanning a menu to find your favorite dish.

Scanning is used for the following :

1. Finding a phone number in a directory.
2. Searching for a specific fact in an article.
3. Looking for answers in an exam passage.

How to scan :

- Move your eyes quickly over the text.
- Look for keywords related to the information you need.
- Use finger or pointer movements to guide your eyes.
- Ignore unnecessary details.

5.3 Tips for Improving Reading Skills

1. **Set clear goals** : Determine what you want to achieve through reading. With clear goal in mind you can make a decision on what to read, how to read and when to read.
2. **Build a routine** : Read daily to develop consistency. For improving reading skills, practice is required and practice can be done only when a task is repeated continuously and consistently. So try to keep a certain amount of time every day for reading, it will help you build a routine and soon you will start enjoying reading.
3. **Diversify materials** : Explore different genres and formats to keep reading interesting. When we go through diverse material, we come across wide range of vocabulary and grammar. Also, diverse material will keep you interested as you will know about variety of topics and can avoid monotony.
4. **Use tools** : Dictionary apps or note-taking tools can aid comprehension. Using dictionary helps in widening your vocabulary and knowledge of pronunciation. The more words you know, the better you will get at reading.
5. **Practice speed reading** : Many people assume that reading slowly leads to better understanding, but research shows that reading faster can actually improve comprehension. This is because when we read in speed, we are less prone to distractions. Also, we understand the overall meaning rather than focussing on single words. This happens because comprehension can be achieved by understanding the relation between words and sentences and putting everything together rather than understanding words or sentences separately. This is why speed reading enhances memory retention also.

5.4 Techniques for Effective Reading

To enhance comprehension and efficiency in reading, the following techniques are invaluable. They enable readers to approach texts strategically, depending on their purpose and the type of material being read.

1. Skimming and scanning

- As discussed above, skimming is take a moment to preview the text of any reading material and read quickly without pausing to study the details. Skimming helps to understand :
 - For which audience the material is written.
 - What type of text it is (report, formal, article etc.).
 - What the purpose of the author is (to describe, to instruct, to persuade, to inform).
 - The general content of the text.
- Studying any material in more detail, after skimming, reading more slowly and carefully and looking for specific information that you are interested in is called scanning. Both techniques save time and help in efficiently extracting relevant information.

2. Structure of text

- **Understanding the structure** :
 - Most written content follows a logical structure such as introduction, body and conclusion.
 - Recognizing patterns like chronological order, problem - solution or cause - effect enhances comprehension.
- **How to analyze structure** :
 - **Pay attention to paragraph organization** : Is the main idea stated first or summarized later ?
 - **Look for transition words** : Words like *however, therefore, in addition* signal relationships between ideas.
 - **Identify sections and subsections** : These provide clarity on the scope of the content.
- **Example** :
 - A scientific article may include sections such as *Abstract, Methods, Results and Discussion*, making it easier to navigate and extract needed information.
- Thus, understanding the structure aids in predicting content, making it easier to retain and recall information.

3. Punctuation

- **Role of punctuation in reading :**

- Punctuation marks such as commas, periods, colons, and semicolons guide the reader in understanding the tone, pauses and flow of the text.
- Misinterpretation of punctuation can lead to confusion or misunderstanding of the message.

- **Tips for paying attention to punctuation :**

- **Commas :** Indicate short pauses or separate items in a list.
o *Example :* "Let's eat, Grandma" vs. "Let's eat Grandma."
- **Periods and semicolons :** Signal the end of a thought or a connection between ideas.
o *Example :* "The event was canceled; however, it will be rescheduled."
- **Quotation marks :** Highlight direct speech or emphasize certain terms.
- Punctuation clarifies meaning, provides emotional cues and ensures accurate interpretation of the text.

4. Author's and Reader's point of view

- The author's perspective is shaped by their background, purpose and intended audience.
- **How to identify the author's viewpoint :**
 - Look for tone (e.g., neutral, persuasive, critical).
 - Analyze word choice and examples provided.
 - Identify any biases or assumptions.
- **Example :** An author writing about climate change may use data to emphasize urgency or adopt a skeptical tone to question popular beliefs.

Reader's point of view :

- The reader's interpretation depends on their knowledge, experiences and biases.
- A reader may agree, disagree or remain neutral depending on how they relate to the author's argument.

Balancing perspectives :

- Effective reading involves distinguishing the author's intent from one's own assumptions.
- **Reflect critically :** Does the text challenge or confirm your views ?

Understanding both viewpoints enhances critical thinking, helping the reader engage deeply with the text.

Thus, Techniques such as skimming and scanning, analyzing the structure of the text, paying attention to punctuation and understanding perspectives significantly improve reading efficiency and comprehension. By employing these strategies, readers can better navigate complex texts, extract meaningful insights and form well-informed opinions.

5.5 Reading Comprehension

- Reading comprehension is the ability to understand, interpret and analyze a text. It involves more than just reading words-it requires making sense of the information, drawing connections and applying critical thinking.
- In professional life and academics, it is required to read a wide range of text and respond or act upon it. This requires good reading comprehension. Usually, in schools and colleges, reading comprehension is practiced by answering questions about each passage, which helps in improving one's reading skills. Following are the key points for reading comprehension :
 - Read all questions first and mark keywords.
 - Now, read the passage and search for keywords i.e. do scanning of the passage.
 - The moment you get the keywords, go back to question with similar word and solve the question.
 - At the end, you will have answered all direct questions from the passage and also read the entire passage. So by now, you are aware of the theme, implication or message of the passage.
 - This will help you in answering the indirect questions.
- The above method can also help in comprehending complex texts in real life scenarios, the only difference is that in such case you don't have to answer any questions, but you actually have to look for particular information.
- Applying all the techniques presented here can help in better understanding any type of text on any topic. This is why reading is not just a skill but a gateway to lifelong learning, personal growth and cultural enrichment. Whether for knowledge, pleasure or professional advancement, the ability to read effectively is a cornerstone of success in today's information-driven world. Developing and refining reading habits can unlock countless opportunities for understanding and engagement.

Quick bites :

- ✓ Reading is a very important skill which helps in many ways like learning and comprehending complex material.
- ✓ Reading can be extensive or intensive based on the purpose of reading.
- ✓ Skimming is used to get an overview and understand the central idea of the material, while scanning is used to search for specific information.
- ✓ Fast reading is more effective than slow reading as it gives an overall perspective of the text rather than focussing on single word or sentence.
- ✓ Understanding the structure of the text helps in comprehension as it gives an idea about the change in the central idea of a paragraph.
- ✓ Reading headings and subheadings gives overall idea of the text.
- ✓ Paying attention to punctuation marks is important as they give a particular meaning to the text.
- ✓ Understanding author's viewpoint and being able to balance between one's own thoughts and author's perspective is important to truly understand a text.

Review Questions

1. Explain the difference between hearing and listening. (Refer section 5.1.2)
2. What are the barriers to effective listening ? (Refer section 5.1.4)
3. Explain the importance of listening. (Refer section 5.1.2)
4. What are the traits of a good listener ? (Refer section 5.1.5)
5. Give tips for effective listening. (Refer section 5.1.5)
6. What is the importance of reading ? (Refer section 5.2)
7. Explain different techniques for effective reading. (Refer section 5.3)
8. Give tips for improving reading skills. (Refer section 5.1.5)
9. Explain types of reading. (Refer section 5.2)
10. Write a note on : 1) Skimming, 2) Scanning. (Refer section 5.2)



Unit 6

6

Enhancing Language through Literature

Syllabus

The Red Rice Granary by Sudha Murty, The Gift of Magi by O. Henry, The World-Renowned Nose by V.M. Basheer, The Lady or, The Tiger? by Frank R. Stockton

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